

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

12 April 2016

To an individual Bahá'í

Dear Bahá'í Friend,

The Universal House of Justice has received your email letter of 26 January 2016 requesting guidance concerning the desire of you and your husband to limit the size of your family given that, in light of your age and health, you do not feel you could complete another pregnancy. The conscientious manner in which you have approached the matter is appreciated. We have been asked to reply as follows.

There is no direct or explicit guidance in the Writings of Bahá'u'lláh or 'Abdu'l-Bahá on the subject of birth control; this matter has been left for the decision of the House of Justice. In response to questions asked by Bahá'ís on previous occasions, the House of Justice has explained that married couples can decide to use birth control methods to delay the timing of a first pregnancy, to control the spacing between pregnancies, or to limit the size of their family.

Some birth control methods act to prevent fertilization, some act after fertilization has occurred to prevent implantation or to abort the fertilized ovum, while in the case of others there is a difference of opinion as to how they work. There is no objection to contraceptives which prevent the occurrence of fertilization. However, it would be improper for a Bahá'í to use a method the effect of which would be to terminate a pregnancy even at its earliest stage, since the Teachings state that the soul comes into being at conception.

It is understood that within the medical profession there is a difference of opinion as to how intrauterine devices work, that is, whether they prevent fertilization or whether they prevent the fertilized ovum from attaching to the wall of the uterus. Yet the Writings do not clearly define when during the biological process "conception" occurs. Indeed, one understanding of conception is that it coincides with fertilization; yet another is that it occurs following fertilization and implantation, the onset of pregnancy. Thus, it may not be possible to know when the association of the soul with the material form occurs, and such questions may be insoluble by human thought or investigation since they relate to mysteries of the spiritual world and the nature of the soul itself.

With regard to the use of a surgical procedure as a form of birth control, this is permissible if the procedure is reversible. In light of the purpose of marriage, the House of Justice has generally been reluctant to condone irreversible sterilization as a method to be used by a couple to avoid having additional children. Permanent sterilization is an action with far-reaching implications and results beyond those usually necessary for the immediate purpose of limiting the size of a family. In this contingent world, it is not possible to be certain of what the future holds, and therefore it is necessary to guard against too easily making a choice to relinquish a God-given capacity, which later may become a cause of regret. Therefore, it is preferable to use other methods of preventing conception to which one may have recourse. Nevertheless, there may be medical circumstances or other compelling reasons that would justify such a procedure. In your case, if the medical advice you are given indicates that you would suffer too severely from further pregnancies, you would be

justified in considering such a step.

In arriving at a decision as to the best method of birth control to use, the friends must take into consideration the methods available to them and be guided by the Bahá'í principles involved, the best medical advice they can obtain, and their own consciences.

It is hoped that the considerations discussed above will be of assistance to you and your husband as you weigh the options before you. You are assured of the supplications of the House of Justice at the Sacred Threshold that your family may be surrounded by the confirmations of the Blessed Beauty and guided and sustained by His grace and bountiful favour.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

2016–2021

The Five Year Plan

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]